Childhood

Poet: Markus Natten | Core Theme: Loss of Innocence, Rationalism & Individuality

Prescribed Textbook: **Hornbill** (Class 11th Core English) • Board: **JKBOSE / CBSE**

1. Poem Overview & Philosophical Inquiry

Childhood by **Markus Natten** is a poignant introspective poem that investigates the elusive transition from childhood innocence into mature adulthood. The poet embarks on a reflective quest to identify the precise moment and developmental milestone when he ceased being a carefree child and crossed into the complex, disillusioned world of adults.

The poem's structure is defined by an engaging progression: the first three stanzas repeatedly ask *'When did my childhood go?'* and identify three distinct stages of maturation—**Rationalism**, **Disillusionment with Adult Hypocrisy**, and **Individuality**. The final stanza shifts the inquiry from *'When'* to *'Where did my childhood go?'*, culminating in a bittersweet revelation.

2. Stanza I: The Dawn of Rationalism & Logic

In the opening stanza, the poet wonders if his childhood vanished on the day he completed eleven years of age: *'Was it the day I ceased to be eleven?'*

During this period, his cognitive faculties matured into logical and rational inquiry:

- **Geography vs. Myth:** As a young boy, he had unquestioningly believed in mythological concepts of **Hell and Heaven**. However, when studying geography, he realised that neither Hell nor Heaven could be found on maps, globes, or atlases.
- **Logical Deduction:** Since these places had no geographical existence, he deduced rationally that they were merely imaginary fairy tales (*'could not be, / Was that the day!'*). The awakening of scientific curiosity and analytical reasoning marked the initial fracture of unquestioning childhood simplicity.

3. Stanza II: Discovering Adult Hypocrisy

In the second stanza, Natten considers whether his childhood ended when he unmasked the dual nature of grown-ups: *'Was it the time I realised that adults were not / All they seemed to be?'*

He noticed a glaring contradiction between adult preachings and adult actions:

- **Preach Love, Act Cruelly:** Grown-ups constantly spoke about universal love, kindness, and moral duty, urging children to be affectionate. Yet, their own daily lives were rife with selfishness, deceit, petty quarrels, and anger.
- **Disillusionment:** Realizing that adults wear moral masks shattered the poet's blind trust. Understanding human hypocrisy is an unmistakable hallmark of losing naive childhood innocence.

4. Stanza III: The Birth of Individuality & Independent Mind

In the third stanza, the poet examines another crucial rite of passage: the discovery of personal autonomy and independent intellect: *'Was it when I found my mind was really mine, / To use whichever way I choose?'*

This stanza celebrates the emergence of self-identity:

- **Original Thought:** The poet realized that he did not have to passively inherit opinions, prejudices, or ideas dictated by others (*'Producing thoughts that were not those of other people, / But my own, and mine alone'*).
- **Individuality:** The moment a child develops independent judgment and asserts unique identity, the unthinking submission of childhood ceases forever.

5. Stanza IV: Where Has Childhood Gone? (The Final Revelation)

Having examined *when* childhood slipped away, the poet changes his question in the fourth stanza to: *'Where did my childhood go?'*

He answers his own question with gentle, poignant closure:

- **A Forgotten Realm:** Childhood has retreated into *'some forgotten place'* that adults can never physically re-enter.
- **Hidden in an Infant's Face:** The lost purity, uncorrupted innocence, and simplicity of childhood continue to live on, clearly visible and preserved in the pristine, smiling face of a newborn infant (*'That's all I know'*). While an individual inevitably loses their childhood to the demands of maturity, childhood as an immortal state of purity is continually reborn in every new infant.

KEY EXAMINATION TAKEAWAYS & POETIC DEVICES

- **Refrain:** The repeated questions *'When did my childhood go?'* (stanzas 1–3) and the concluding exclamation *'Was that the day!'* emphasize the poet's relentless inner quest.
- **Shift in Inquiry:** Stanzas 1–3 focus on time (*'When'*); Stanza 4 shifts focus to space and preservation (*'Where'*).
- **Three Stages of Maturation:**
  1. *Rationalism:* Looking for Hell and Heaven in Geography.
  2. *Hypocrisy Awareness:* Recognizing adults' double standards.
  3. *Individuality:* Realizing *'my mind was really mine'*.
- **Antithesis:** Contrast between opposites: *'Hell and Heaven'*; *'talked of love'* vs. *'did not act so lovingly'*.
- **Symbolism:** The **Infant's Face** symbolizes untainted innocence, untouched by societal hypocrisy or cynical logic.